

crossing over the River Tiber, the region's largest river. The villages prospered and grew in size. Within less than 300 years, they had spread out across the hilltops, and by about 750 BCE, they had joined together to form a town. It was this early town that marked the birth of the city that would later become known as Rome.

The hated kings of Rome

Rome lay in a region of Italy called Latium, which was divided into different city-states. (You can think of them as "tribal areas.") The inhabitants of Latium were known as Latins. Immediately to their north was the region of Etruria, the home of a cultured people

called the Etruscans. For a time, the Etruscans were the most powerful people in northern Italy. In the 7th century BCE, the Etruscans gained control of Rome, and for about 100 years, the city was ruled by Etruscan kings.

By 509 BCE, the Roman people had had enough of Etruscan rule. They rebelled and threw Tarquin the Proud, the last of the hated Etruscan kings, out of Rome. From then on, Rome was ruled by a group of its leading citizens. It had become a republic—a state

A FARMER FROM ROMAN TIMES WOULD STILL RECOGNIZE TODAY'S COUNTRYSIDE NEAR ROME, WITH ITS OLIVE AND CYPRESS TREES, VINEYARDS, AND SMALL FIELDS.

